grandson, who would submit to Jahangir in 1615, commissioned a truly stupendous work in the 1640s comprising a staggering 400 paintings of joyous colour and abandon, many of which were painted by the leading artist of the time, Sahibuddin, a Mewari Muslim. This Mewar Ramayan is considered the finest and most complete version of this epic ever commissioned by a Hindu patron.

As for Badauni, Akbar's most prolific translator despite all his many misgivings, though he admitted that the Ramayan was marginally better than the tales of the Mahabharat, he baulked at writing a preface for it. 'I seek refuge in God from that black book,' he wrote despairingly, 'which is as rotten as the book of my life.' Badauni knew that Akbar would expect from him a work like the preface of the Mahabharat, which Abu'l Fazl had written in lyrical and expansive style, praising the knowledge contained in the Mahabharat and the cross-cultural enterprise undertaken by Akbar. Unable also to conceive a work in which he would not be allowed to include praise for the Prophet Muhammad, Badauni demurred.

But now, alongside the eclectic works of translation that were taking place in Lahore, Akbar decided that his empire was finally secure enough for him to begin the monumental texts that would anchor his legacy within the history of Hindustan, the history of Islam, the history of the Timurids, and the history of mankind itself.

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*Ethiopia

*Short poems best suited for epigrams, satires, and light verse.